

SECTION SIXTEEN

THE WEB OF SYSTEMS

A world isn't a collection of isolated facts. It's a web of interconnected systems, and when you change one thing, it ripples outward. If magic exists, it changes warfare, which changes politics, which changes the economy, which changes daily life. If your world has dragons, someone has to feed them, which means a dragon-feed economy, which means farms or hunting grounds, which means territorial disputes.

In romantasy, this interconnectedness matters because hollow worldbuilding creates hollow stakes. If your magic system has no impact on how society functions, readers won't believe it matters. If your court has no economy, the political marriages feel decorative rather than desperate. And if the fantasy elements don't integrate with the romance, you end up with two separate stories awkwardly sharing page space.

You've built individual systems throughout this workbook. This section helps you test whether those systems connect to each other, and whether they all connect to your romance.

The Web Principle

Your world is a web, not a shelf.

A shelf holds separate items. A magic system here, a political structure there, a culture over there. They sit side by side but don't touch. A web transmits vibrations. Pull one thread and others move. Tug hard enough and the whole structure reshapes.

This makes a huge difference for the reader. A world built like a shelf feels like a collection of Wikipedia entries: detailed, thorough, inert. A world built like a web feels alive. Change one thing and consequences ripple outward. Ban magic and you create a black market. Create a black market and you create criminals. Create criminals and you create an underworld your heroine might need to navigate. One decision cascades.

For romantasy writers, the web principle is essential because your romance lives inside this web. Every time your characters pull a thread, choosing each other, defying a law, crossing a border, breaking a taboo, it should send vibrations through the system. If their love doesn't disturb the web, the stakes aren't real. And if the web doesn't constrain their love, the obstacles aren't earned.

Fourth Wing is a masterclass in web-building. Dragon bonding (magic) determines military rank (politics), which determines who has power and resources (economy), which shapes the entire culture of Basgiath (daily life), which creates the hierarchy that puts Violet and Xaden on opposite sides (romance). Pull the thread of dragon bonding and everything else moves. That's why the romance has real stakes. It's not just two people with feelings; it's two people embedded in systems that have opinions about those feelings.

The test is simple: when your characters choose each other, does anything in the world change? If the answer is nothing, your systems aren't connected. If the answer is *everything shifts*, you've built a web.

Pull one thread in your world. What moves?

Pick one decision, rule, or feature in your world — a law, a magical property, a geographic barrier — and trace what happens when it changes. If changing it doesn't affect at least two other systems, it may not be woven into the web yet.

THE THREAD YOU PULL	FIRST SYSTEM THAT MOVES	SECOND SYSTEM THAT MOVES	HOW IT REACHES YOUR ROMANCE
<i>Dragon bonding requires proximity (magic)</i>	<i>Military rank depends on bond strength (politics)</i>	<i>Dragon riders control the best territory (economy)</i>	<i>Violet and Xaden's bond makes them politically dangerous to both sides</i>

A Note Before You Begin

Not every system needs deep testing. If your story is set entirely in one city with no magic, you don't need to stress-test geographic impact or magical economics. Focus on the systems that touch your romance most

directly, the ones creating the obstacles, forced proximity, and stakes that drive your love story. Skip what doesn't serve your story!

Systems in Romantasy

Every worldbuilding element affects others. The table below maps the major systems and their connections. Use it to identify where your web has strong threads and where it might have gaps.

SYSTEM	AFFECTS	WHICH CONNECTS TO
Geography (Section 1)	Resources, borders, travel, isolation	Economy, Politics, Daily Life
Environment (Section 2)	Food, danger, medicine, survival	Economy, Culture, Daily Life
Culture (Section 3)	Values, taboos, customs, identity	Politics, Religion, Romance
Economy (Section 4)	Power, scarcity, labour, trade	Politics, Class, Daily Life
Politics (Section 5)	Laws, power structures, conflict	Everything
Religion (Section 6)	Beliefs, sacred time, moral framework	Culture, Politics, Magic
History (Section 7)	Why things are as they are	Everything
Magic (Section 10)	What's possible, who has power	Everything
Technology (Section 9)	Daily life, communication, warfare	Economy, Politics, Daily Life

The Romance → is shaped by all these forces, creating obstacles and opportunities

But what matters most for your story isn't the connections in the abstract. It's the specific collisions that create romantic tension. When two systems clash, they generate the obstacles and impossible choices that drive great romance.

SYSTEM COLLISION	ROMANTIC PATTERN IT CREATES	EXAMPLE
Magic vs. Law	Forbidden power romance; one has abilities the other must enforce against	Mage falls for the witch-hunter; using her power to save him would condemn them both
Economy vs. Culture	Class-crossed lovers; wealth divides what the heart wants to unite	Noble heir whose estate depends on a marriage alliance falls for the merchant with no lineage
Politics vs. Religion	Sacred vs. strategic love; the heart violates what faith or state demands	A priestess whose vows forbid attachment is politically matched with a foreign prince
History vs. Present	Love haunted by the past; old wounds poison new connections	Descendants of warring houses whose ancestors' hatred is the reason their love is treason
Geography vs. Desire	Distance and isolation as romantic obstacle; the world itself keeps them apart	Lovers separated by a cursed sea crossing that can only be made once per year
Culture vs. Magic	Identity crisis romance; choosing love means choosing between who you are and what you can do	A shapeshifter from a culture that considers shifting an abomination falls for someone who loves their true form

Which system collisions create tension in your story?

Pick 2–3 collisions from the table above — or invent your own — and map how they generate obstacles for your romance. The more systems that collide around a single obstacle, the more earned it feels.

SYSTEMS THAT COLLIDE	THE OBSTACLE IT CREATES	HOW IT AFFECTS THE ROMANCE
<i>Magic vs. Law</i>	<i>Feyre's powers make her a political threat in Spring Court</i>	<i>Tamlin's "protection" becomes a cage — love becomes control</i>

Common Mistakes with System Integration

Mistake #1: The Decorative Magic Problem

Magic exists in your world but doesn't affect politics, economy, or daily life. It's a cool power system that floats above the world rather than being embedded in it. Characters use magic in action scenes, but nobody farms with it, heals with it, builds with it, or fights political battles over who controls it. If magic doesn't shape the world, it can't meaningfully shape your characters' obstacles. "Magic is forbidden" feels hollow if there's no economic, political, or cultural reason for the ban. Stakes need roots in systems that feel real. **Does magic affect how food is grown? Messages sent? Sick healed? Buildings constructed? Wealth displayed?** *If magic touches daily life, it creates economic winners and losers — and economic inequality is one of the most grounded romantic obstacles you can build. If magic doesn't touch daily life, you need to know why, because that absence shapes your world too.* (Check against Section 9 — Technology, Section 4 — Economy)

If magic doesn't affect daily life, why not? *The reason magic stays out of daily life — rarity, cost, prohibition, cultural taboo — is often more interesting than the magic itself. It reveals who hoards power and why, which connects directly to the obstacles your romance faces.* Too rare? Expensive? Forbidden? Unreliable? Taboo? Hoarded by elites?

FIX

Ask yourself: does magic affect how food is grown, messages sent, sick healed, buildings constructed, wealth displayed? If not, why not? Is it too rare, expensive, forbidden, unreliable, hoarded by elites? Either show magic's impact on daily life or explain convincingly why it doesn't have one. In *The Priory of the Orange Tree*, magic's connection to religion and political legitimacy means it shapes everything from queenship to warfare.

Mistake #2: The Economyless Court

Elaborate court politics. Scheming nobles, political marriages, power plays. But no sense of where wealth comes from. The kingdom seems to run on intrigue alone. Characters fight for “power” without any concrete resources, trade routes, or economic stakes grounding the conflict. Political marriages only feel desperate when the economic consequences of refusal are real. “Marry him for the alliance” is weaker than “Marry him or our people starve when his kingdom blocks the mountain passes our grain comes through.” Concrete economic stakes make romantic sacrifice feel earned. **What does your kingdom actually produce that makes it wealthy?** “Marry him for the alliance” is weak. “Marry him or our people starve when his kingdom blocks the mountain passes” is earned. Concrete economic reality gives romantic sacrifice real weight. (Reference Section 4 — Economic Foundation) Agricultural land, mines, magical resources, trade routes, manufacturing, tribute from conquered peoples? _____

_____ **If in conflict with another power, what are they actually fighting over?** Not just “power” — specific resources, territories, economic advantages. The more concrete the stakes, the more a forced political marriage feels like a genuine sacrifice rather than a plot device. _____

FIX

Ground political conflicts in economic reality. Wars cost money. Political marriages secure resources. Ask: what does your kingdom actually produce? What are they fighting over, not just “power” but specific resources, territories, economic advantages? *Bridgerton* gets this right. The marriage market is grounded in concrete economics: dowries, estates, financial ruin, social climbing. Every match has economic stakes, which is why the romantic choices feel genuinely costly rather than decorative.



Mistake #3: The Costless Magic Problem

Magic does anything the plot needs with no consistent cost or limitation. When characters need to escape, magic provides. When they need information, magic delivers. But when the plot needs tension, magic conveniently fails or is forgotten. If magic can solve any problem, romantic obstacles dissolve. “We can’t be together because of the magical barrier” falls apart if magic has already been shown solving bigger problems with no consequence. Limits create stakes, and stakes create romance. **What can’t magic do? What problems does it fail to solve?** *If magic can do anything the plot needs, romantic obstacles dissolve the moment a character reaches for their power. The limits you set here are what keep your stakes real — and keep readers trusting your world.* (Reference Section 10 — Magic Limits) _____

_____ **Why hasn’t magic solved poverty, disease, war, or death?** *The answer reveals what’s fundamentally broken in your world — and broken systems are where the most powerful romantic stakes live. If magic could fix everything, there’d be nothing worth fighting for.* _____

FIX

Define what magic cannot do and stick to it. Ask: why hasn’t magic solved poverty, disease, war, or death? The answer reveals what’s fundamentally broken in your world, and what stakes remain meaningful. In *Uprooted*, magic’s cost in exhaustion and corruption means every use is a genuine sacrifice.



Mistake #4: The Culture Without History Problem

Rich, detailed cultural customs, taboos, and traditions — but no sense of where they came from. The culture feels invented rather than evolved. Characters follow rules that exist because the author put them there, not because history created them. Cultural obstacles only feel earned when they have roots. “Our people forbid this” is weaker than “Our people forbid this because the last time it happened, thousands died.” A taboo with historical weight makes defying it feel genuinely dangerous, not just rebellious.

Pick your most important custom or taboo. What created it? *If you can't trace a custom back to a specific event or pressure, it may feel arbitrary to readers — and arbitrary obstacles create weaker romantic tension.* (Reference Section 7 — History) Historical event, environmental pressure, religious revelation, social need, trauma? _____

FIX

Trace your biggest customs and taboos back to their origin. Every prohibition was once a response to something real — a catastrophe, a war, a famine, a betrayal. Finding that origin deepens both the worldbuilding and the romantic stakes, because now your characters aren't just breaking a rule. They're challenging centuries of trauma.

Testing Your Systems

The following subsections help you stress-test whether your major systems are genuinely connected, both to each other and to your romance. For each system, the worldbuilding questions and the romantic implications are woven together, because in a well-built world, they're inseparable.

Geography and Resources

(Reference: Section 1: Geography and Environment; Section 4: Economy)

Resources are where geography becomes power. Whoever has control over something that people are short on, has control over who depends on them, and dependency is one of the most potent engines of romantic tension. The person who controls the water, the medicine, the safe passage, holds power over the one who needs it. This imbalance can force proximity, create reluctant alliance, or make desire feel like capitulation.

What are your world's most valuable or rarest resources?

(Reference Section 4 for how these drive economy)

YOUR ANSWER

Where do these resources come from geographically?

WHERE DO THESE RESOURCES COME FROM GEOGRAPHICALLY?

Who controls access — and how did they get control?

Conquest, natural borders, treaty, magical ability, historical claim?

(Reference Section 5 for political control, Section 7 for historical claims)

YOUR ANSWER

How does resource control create inequality, tension, or power imbalance?

HOW DOES RESOURCE CONTROL CREATE INEQUALITY, TENSION, OR POWER IMBALANCE?

Romantasy Connection: Does resource scarcity or control affect your characters' relationship?

Does one control something the other needs? Does fighting over resources force proximity? Does an economic alliance require their union?

YOUR ANSWER



Magic doesn't just create interesting ways of using power. It reshapes who has wealth, who has opportunity, and who gets left behind. If magic can heal, there's a healing economy. If magic can build, there's a construction revolution. If magic can kill, there's a weapons market. And wherever there's economic inequality, there's romantic tension, because a relationship across an economic divide forces both parties to see things from a perspective they weren't used to.

Beyond economics, magic in romantasy often creates direct romantic mechanics. Bonds, compulsions, and connections that shape the love story itself. These aren't metaphors for attraction. They're literal magical forces that bind, reveal, or test the lovers.

ACOTAR uses a mating bond that allows Feyre and Rhysand to feel each other's emotions no matter how far apart they are, creates shared power, and causes physical pain when violated. In *Fourth Wing*, dragon bonds create an "emotional bleed" where riders feel their dragons' desires, including romantic ones. When Tairn and Sgaeyl mate, Violet and Xaden both feel it, and it becomes difficult to discern whose desire belongs to whom. In *From Blood and Ash*, the heartmate bond is soul-deep, tied to the magical fabric of the world itself.

When using any magical romantic mechanism, the key craft question is this: **does it amplify feelings that already exist, or does it originate them?** Readers reward bonds that deepen existing chemistry. They resist bonds that do the love for the characters. In ACOTAR, the mating bond doesn't appear until the end of book two. By that time Feyre and Rhys had spent months building trust, so when it arrives, it amplifies what's already there. Bonds that snap into place on first meeting can feel like a shortcut.

Does your magic system create any direct romantic bonds or connections? Mating bonds, soul bonds, magical compatibility, psychic links, emotional bleed through shared magic, truth-compelling enchantments? If so, what are the rules?

BOND/ MECHANISM	HOW IT WORKS	WHEN IT ACTIVATES	WHAT IT COSTS	CAN IT BE RESISTED?
<i>Mating bond (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>Emotional awareness of partner; shared power; physical pull</i>	<i>End of book 2, after trust is built</i>	<i>Pain when denied; vulnerability to enemies</i>	<i>Yes — Feyre can accept or reject it</i>

Does this magical mechanism amplify or originate your characters' feelings?

Readers trust bonds that deepen chemistry the characters have already built. If the bond originates feelings, your characters should question and resist it — choosing love on their own terms.

YOUR ANSWER

Does the bond raise consent or agency concerns — and how do your characters grapple with that?
If magic compels attraction, forces proximity, or reveals private feelings without permission, the characters should acknowledge the tension. The best romantasy doesn't gloss over this.

YOUR ANSWER

Which other systems does the magical bond collide with?

A bond that's politically inconvenient, culturally taboo, or historically feared creates far richer tension than one that exists in isolation. The more systems your bond touches, the more it costs to accept.

Which other worldbuilding systems (politics, culture, religion, history, economy) does your magical bond collide with? For each relevant system, describe how it interacts with the bond and what tension that creates.

YOUR ANSWER

Testing Magic's Economic Impact

Continue in Section 10

Magic System; Section 4 — Economy

Skip if your world has no magic.

Who can use magic?

Who has access to magic determines who has power — and power imbalances are the engine of romantic tension.

Everyone? Bloodlines? Trained individuals? Random selection?

YOUR ANSWER

Can magic create wealth or resources directly?

If magic generates wealth, the gap between magical haves and non-magical have-nots becomes an economic divide — and economic divides create some of the most grounded romantic obstacles.

Conjuring food, transmuting materials, enhanced crops, healing for profit, teleportation for trade?

YOUR ANSWER

If magic can create resources, why isn't everyone wealthy?

The answer to this question reveals what's fundamentally unfair about your world — and unfairness is where romantic stakes live.

Cost in energy/life, rare components, illegal, inferior products, years of training, limited scale?

YOUR ANSWER

What jobs exist because of magic — or were made obsolete by it?

Labour disruption creates class resentment, displaced communities, and characters whose identities are tied to skills that no longer matter — all rich ground for romance across a divide.

(Reference Section 4 for labor and economic structures)

YOUR ANSWER

How does magic change the economy of warfare?

If magical soldiers are worth more, your love interest's value might be measured in military utility rather than personhood — and loving someone the state considers a weapon creates its own tension.

(Reference Section 5 for military structures)

Are magical soldiers worth more? Do mage-heavy kingdoms dominate? Magical arms race? Black market for magical weapons/services?

YOUR ANSWER

Romantasy Connection: How does the magic economy affect your romance?

Does one profit from magic while the other suffers? Economic inequality between magical and non-magical?

Does magical ability determine social class and therefore marriageability?

YOUR ANSWER

Politics and Law

(Reference: Section 5: Government, Power and Law)

Laws are the codified will of those in power, and in romantasy, they're often the wall between your characters. Effective romantic obstacles should be laws which have an obvious reason behind them, one that readers can

relate to even if they disagree. A law forbidding inter-species marriage that exists because a past union caused a magical catastrophe is more compelling than a law that exists because the author needed an obstacle.

Culture is the invisible architecture of your world. The values, taboos, and assumptions that your characters live with every day. Unlike laws, cultural constraints don't need enforcers. They're enforced by shame, ostracism, identity, and the voice inside a character's head that says *this is wrong* even when their heart says otherwise. This internal conflict, desire vs. cultural identity, is some of the most powerful romantic tension you can create.

What a culture values most — honour, loyalty, freedom, magical power, wealth, lineage — shapes what characters believe about themselves and what they think love should look like. Those values should show up in the laws and political structures you've built: a culture that prizes honour will have duelling laws; one that prizes lineage will have inheritance complications. The values from Section 3 should manifest in the laws from Section 5.

Equally important are the taboos. The best taboos have roots that go deep — they exist because breaking them once caused real harm. Magic might be forbidden because mages once conquered. Inter-species relationships might be taboo because a past war created lasting prejudice. When taboos connect to practical realities, cultural obstacles feel earned rather than arbitrary. And when your romance violates or challenges those values, the most painful kind of obstacle emerges: the one where a character must choose between who they love and who they are.

Testing Political Consistency

Continue in Section 5

Government, Power & Law

What determines who holds political power?

Heredity, military strength, wealth, magical ability, religious authority, democratic process?

YOUR ANSWER

If magic exists, do magical users hold power or are they controlled?

If mages are powerful, why don't they rule everything? If non-mages rule, how do they control mages?

(This should align with your magic system from Section 10)

YOUR ANSWER

What laws exist specifically because of your world's unique features?

Laws regulating magic, forbidding inter-species relationships, governing dragon ownership, protecting non-magical citizens, controlling trade in rare resources?

YOUR ANSWER

Who benefits from these laws? Who is oppressed?

WHO BENEFITS FROM THESE LAWS? WHO IS OPPRESSED?

Romantasy Connection: Which law creates the biggest obstacle for your romance?

Is their relationship illegal, politically inconvenient, or magically dangerous?

YOUR ANSWER

If they break this law, what are the specific, concrete consequences?

Not just “scandal” — actual legal punishment (reference Section 5 for justice system):

YOUR ANSWER



Testing Cultural Consistency

Continue in Section 3

Culture, Customs & Daily Life

What does your culture value most?

Honor, loyalty, freedom, magical power, wealth, lineage, martial prowess, scholarship?

YOUR ANSWER

How do these values show up in laws and political structure?

(Values from Section 3 should manifest in laws from Section 5)

If honor is valued — dueling laws? If lineage matters — inheritance complications? If magical power is valued — special legal status for mages?

YOUR ANSWER

What is taboo or shameful — and why?

What threatens social order, challenges power, violates religion, connects to historical trauma?

(Reference Section 6 for religious taboos, Section 7 for historical sources)

YOUR ANSWER

How do taboos connect to practical realities?

If magic is forbidden — because mages once conquered? If inter-species relationships are taboo — past war created prejudice? If showing emotion is shameful — harsh environment requires stoicism?

YOUR ANSWER

Romantasy Connection: How does your romance violate or challenge cultural values?

Does their relationship represent something the culture fears? Does choosing love mean rejecting cultural identity?

YOUR ANSWER

Religion and Faith

(Reference: Section 6: Religion and Belief Systems)

Religious systems are among the biggest, most emotionally charged obstacles to romance in romantasy because they operate on the level of identity, not just law. Political laws can be broken with courage. Cultural taboos can be defied with willpower. But religious convictions live inside a character's soul. They shape what they believe about themselves, what they think they deserve, and whether their desires are sacred or sinful. When love conflicts with faith, the character isn't just risking punishment. They're risking damnation, or the loss of who they believe themselves to be.

Poppy's role as the Maiden in *From Blood and Ash* is defined by religious prohibition: her life is "solitary, never to be touched, never to experience pleasure." Falling in love with Hawke isn't just forbidden. It's blasphemous. Each stolen moment is a moment of divine transgression, and that weight makes each moment feel dangerously earned. In *The Priory of the Orange Tree*, Riva's vow of celibacy to the Nameless Order pits his faith against his heart, and when he chooses love over his vow, it's an act of individual autonomy and a significant moment in defining what's sacred. Obstacles like these are not arbitrary. They represent fundamental conflicts of identity in which the choice to love is also the choice to redefine what's holy.

Does your world have an organised religion or belief system? If so, what does it demand of its followers? Vows, rituals, prohibitions, codes of behaviour? Religious demands that touch on love, marriage, desire, or bodily autonomy are where your romance will collide with faith.

YOUR ANSWER

Does your religion impose restrictions on love, desire, or partnership?

These are the specific mechanisms that create romantic obstacles — vows of celibacy, prohibitions on cross-faction unions, arranged marriage requirements, purity rituals. Map the restrictions that matter most for your romance.

RELIGIOUS RESTRICTION	WHO IT APPLIES TO	WHAT IT FORBIDS	WHAT HAPPENS IF BROKEN
<i>Maiden's vow of purity (FBAA)</i>	<i>The Chosen Maiden (Poppy)</i>	<i>Physical touch, pleasure, romantic attachment</i>	<i>Loss of Maiden status; divine punishment; endangers the kingdom's protection</i>

Is love itself considered sacred, sinful, or something in between?

A faith that treats love as sacred creates different tension than one that treats desire as dangerous. In some systems, love is the highest devotion. In others, it's a distraction from duty, or an outright transgression. Where your world's faith falls determines the emotional register of every romantic scene.

YOUR ANSWER

Does your world distinguish between “sacred bonds” (arranged, ordained, prophesied) and “chosen bonds” (personal love)?

This is one of the richest conflicts in romantasy. The strongest versions make both bonds feel legitimate — so breaking the sacred one costs something real.

If your world distinguishes between ‘sacred bonds’ (arranged, ordained, prophesied) and ‘chosen bonds’ (personal love), describe both, why they conflict, and what breaking the sacred bond costs.

YOUR ANSWER

Are there religious authority figures who enforce these restrictions?

Religious enforcers carry both institutional power and moral authority — defying them feels weightier than defying a political figure alone. The High Priest in FBAA and the Celestial Emperor in Daughter of the Moon Goddess aren’t just political obstacles. They claim divine mandate.

YOUR ANSWER

Do the gods (or divine forces) in your world take an active interest in your characters' romance?

Divine intervention can work for or against the lovers. If your world has active deities, their stance on the romance — blessing, opposing, or engineering it — raises stakes significantly.

YOUR ANSWER

How does your romance interact with your faith system?

The best faith-based romantic obstacles are ones where choosing love requires the character to redefine what's sacred — not abandon faith entirely, but find a deeper truth within it.

How does your romance interact with your world's faith system? Does it violate a religious law, break a sacred vow, fulfil an unexpected prophecy, prove a doctrine wrong, or challenge a corrupt authority? What does this cost the character, and what does it reveal about the faith?

YOUR ANSWER

Daily Life and Difference

(Reference: Section 3: Culture; Section 9: Technology and Infrastructure)

The small frictions of daily life, how you eat, how you sleep, what you consider clean, what you find comfortable, create some of the most authentic romantic tension. When two people from different backgrounds come together they have more than disagreements over politics. They disagree about whether shoes belong inside, whether silence is comfortable or hostile, whether a meal should be shared or private. It's these small collisions that show us how far apart two people are, and creating a bridge to close that gap is part of falling in love.

Testing Daily Life Consistency

Continue in Section 3

Culture; Section 9 — Technology & Infrastructure

What does a normal day look like for common people?

How do they get food, water, shelter? Travel? Communicate? Find entertainment?

YOUR ANSWER

How is the protagonist's daily life different from average?

Richer, poorer, more powerful, more restricted, more free?

YOUR ANSWER

How is the love interest's daily life different from the protagonist's?

HOW IS THE LOVE INTEREST'S DAILY LIFE DIFFERENT FROM THE PROTAGONIST'S?

Romantasy Connection: What daily life difference creates friction?

Different social classes? One takes for granted what the other struggles for? What misunderstanding arises from different lived experiences?

YOUR ANSWER

Map the small collisions between your protagonists' daily lives.

These aren't the big political or magical differences — they're the mundane ones. What feels normal to one and alien to the other? These small frictions reveal how far apart two people really are, and bridging them is part of falling in love.

DAILY HABIT OR ASSUMPTION	CHARACTER WHO HAS IT	HOW THE OTHER CHARACTER REACTS	WHAT IT REVEALS ABOUT THEIR DIVIDE
<i>Silence at meals is respectful (Illyrian custom)</i>	<i>Cassian</i>	<i>Nesta finds it cold and isolating</i>	<i>His culture values discipline; hers values connection through conversation</i>



When you build a world with decorative elements, you get decorated obstacles, and your reader will be able to tell the difference. If an element only connects to one system, it's sitting on top of your world. An element woven through three or more systems has roots that go back far enough to create real stakes for your romance. If a system isn't connected, don't panic. Don't leave it alone either. Below are three practical approaches to deepening integration.

Reverse-engineer from the romance. Take your biggest romantic obstacle and start tracing backward. What systems could generate that obstacle? If their love is forbidden, *why*? Is it law, culture, religion, magic, economics, or history? The more systems you can find that create that obstacle, the more real it feels. Often you'll find a system that *should* be connected but isn't, and the connection was just waiting to be found.

Look for cascade effects. Change one thing and ask what else changes. If you add a law forbidding inter-species marriage (politics), ask: why would such a law exist? Perhaps a past union caused a magical catastrophe (history + magic). Perhaps the resulting prejudice shaped cultural values (culture). Perhaps one species controls resources the other needs, and the law became a tool for economic power (economy). With one well-placed connection, you can create a chain reaction throughout three or four systems if you follow the logic.

Add a shared origin event. The fastest way to create a link between two otherwise unrelated systems is to give them a shared historical cause. If your magic system and your political structure feel disconnected, ask: was there a time when magic influenced politics? A mage rebellion that led to anti-magic laws? A magical catastrophe that reshaped borders? By establishing a common origin event, you can create a single thread that ties your entire web together, and gives your romance a historical weight that makes its obstacles feel centuries in the making.

Try one of these strategies now.

Pick the approach that fits your world best. If you have a disconnected system, this is where you fix it.

Reverse-engineer: What's your biggest romantic obstacle, and which systems generate it?

Trace backward from the obstacle. The more systems you can connect to it, the more earned it feels.

What is your biggest romantic obstacle? Trace it backward: which worldbuilding systems (politics, history, culture, magic, economy, religion) generate this obstacle, and how do they compound to make it feel earned?

YOUR ANSWER

Cascade: Pick one worldbuilding decision and follow the ripple effects through at least three systems.
Start with something concrete: a law, a resource, a magical rule. Then ask “what else changes?” at each step.

THE DECISION	SYSTEM IT AFFECTS	WHAT CHANGES	NEXT SYSTEM IT RIPPLES INTO
<i>Anti-magic law (politics)</i>	<i>History</i>	<i>Rooted in a past mage rebellion</i>	<i>Culture — prejudice against mage-born</i>

Shared origin: What single historical event could connect two systems that currently feel unrelated?

The event doesn't need to be dramatic — a famine, a discovery, a treaty can reshape multiple systems at once.

YOUR ANSWER

The Integration Exercise

Choose one major worldbuilding element to test its connections:

THE ELEMENT

Choose one major worldbuilding element and test its connections. How does it affect geography, economy, politics, culture, and your romance? If it doesn't connect to at least three of these, it might be decorative.

YOUR ANSWER

If this element doesn't connect to at least three rows, it might be decorative. Deepen its integration or consider whether you need it.

The Antagonist and Systems

Your antagonist doesn't exist outside of the world they inhabit. They're shaped by, and often represent, the systems you've built. A true antagonist should be an embodiment of the forces keeping your protagonists apart. They're not just a person to defeat. They're the human face of a system to challenge.

Madoc in *The Cruel Prince* is a great example of this. He isn't just a villain driven by a personal grudge. He IS the fae political system that treats humans as lesser. He genuinely loves Jude while embodying everything that oppresses her. To defeat Madoc isn't just about removing one person; it's about challenging the entire power structure he's an extension of. This is what makes him both so frightening and so compelling.

How does your antagonist benefit from current systems?

Do they profit from laws, economic structures, cultural prejudices, political arrangements that also create obstacles for your romance?

YOUR ANSWER

Does your antagonist represent or embody a system that oppresses your protagonists?

Are they the face of the law, the culture, the political structure that keeps your characters apart?

YOUR ANSWER

What would your antagonist lose if your protagonists succeed?

Power, wealth, status, worldview, identity, control?

YOUR ANSWER

Does defeating the antagonist require changing the system — or just removing one person?

If removing the antagonist doesn't change the system, will another antagonist rise? Does lasting change require more than victory?

YOUR ANSWER

If defeating the antagonist doesn't change the system, what else needs to change?

Map the systemic changes required for your protagonists' victory to be lasting — not just personal. If removing the antagonist leaves the oppressive system intact, the happy ending hasn't truly been earned.

YOUR ANSWER

Is the antagonist wrong about everything, or do they have a point about the world?

Complex antagonists often represent legitimate concerns taken too far, or defend systems that have real value alongside their oppression:

YOUR ANSWER

System Trade-Offs

The struggle between two good things creates interesting choices for characters. The natural result of connected systems is the trade-offs that drive the most compelling romantic tension. Not “good vs. evil” but “good vs. good”. Two things the character values that cannot coexist.

In *Fourth Wing*, Violet finds herself at exactly this crossroads: loyalty to her nation and her mother’s legacy (duty, honour, the identity she’s built her life around) vs. the truth Xaden represents about the war (justice, honesty, a future that requires dismantling what she’s been taught to believe). Each option has real value. There are no bad guys here. And the romance forces her to confront a choice she could have avoided if she’d never let him close enough to matter.

What trade-offs exist in your world?

Safety vs. freedom? Tradition vs. progress? Individual happiness vs. collective good? Loyalty vs. truth? Power vs. connection?

YOUR ANSWER

What trade-off does your protagonist face?

What two things they value are in conflict?

YOUR ANSWER

What trade-off does your love interest face?

WHAT TRADE-OFF DOES YOUR LOVE INTEREST FACE?

Do they face the same trade-off differently, or different trade-offs entirely?

When protagonists face the same dilemma from opposite sides, every conversation becomes charged. When they face different dilemmas, they struggle to understand each other's stakes. Both create tension — but the romantic dynamics differ.

YOUR ANSWER

Does their relationship force them to confront trade-offs they could otherwise avoid?

DOES THEIR RELATIONSHIP FORCE THEM TO CONFRONT TRADE-OFFS THEY COULD OTHERWISE AVOID?

What does each character choose — and what does that choice cost?

PROTAGONIST CHOOSES

AT THE COST OF

LOVE INTEREST CHOOSES

AT THE COST OF

Romantasy is at its best when the relationship has weight beyond the couple themselves. Every choice of the couple affects the systems you've built, because in a web, nothing moves in isolation.

Romantasy-Specific Integration

The Obstacle Test

List the three biggest obstacles keeping your characters apart:

Trace each obstacle to specific worldbuilding:

Obstacle 1 exists because of (which law, cultural value, magical rule, political reality, economic pressure — reference specific sections):

YOUR ANSWER

Obstacle 2 exists because of:

YOUR ANSWER

Obstacle 3 exists because of:

YOUR ANSWER

If any obstacle feels arbitrary, strengthen it by connecting to multiple systems.

The Proximity Test

What worldbuilding element forces your characters into proximity?

Shared mission, institutional requirement (Section 14), magical bond (Section 10), political arrangement (Section 5), geographic isolation (Section 1), economic necessity (Section 4)?

YOUR ANSWER

Does this forced proximity connect to at least two other systems?

Example: A magical bond (Section 10) required by law (Section 5) because historically bonded pairs were weapons (Section 7) and now the kingdom is at war (Section 5 — warfare).

YOUR ANSWER

The Stakes Test

What would they lose if their relationship was discovered or if they chose each other?

WHAT WOULD THEY LOSE IF THEIR RELATIONSHIP WAS DISCOVERED OR IF THEY CHOSE EACH OTHER?

Are these losses connected to concrete worldbuilding?

Loss of political power (Section 5), economic ruin (Section 4), magical consequences (Section 10), cultural exile (Section 3), legal punishment (Section 5), religious condemnation (Section 6)?

YOUR ANSWER

How the Romance Changes the World

This is what takes the ACOTAR series from being a personal love story to something with real impact. Feyre and Rhys's union doesn't just make them happy. It reshapes the political landscape of Prythian. Courts that never spoke begin to ally. Power structures that kept entire populations oppressed start to crack. The way their relationship models a new kind of partnership, one based on equality rather than possession, has real political consequences. Their love matters to the world, not just to them.

If your characters choose each other despite obstacles, what changes?

Do laws get challenged? Alliances shift? Cultural prejudices erode? Magical systems reveal new possibilities? Economic structures reorganise?

YOUR ANSWER

What system that tried to keep them apart is affected by their union?

WHAT SYSTEM THAT TRIED TO KEEP THEM APART IS AFFECTED BY THEIR UNION?

Who else benefits if they succeed?

Others in similar situations? The oppressed? The kingdom? The magical community? Future generations?

YOUR ANSWER

Who loses if they succeed?

Those who benefited from keeping them apart? The antagonist? The old order? People who depended on the systems that are now changing?

YOUR ANSWER

Does their relationship model something new?

A new kind of alliance? Proof that old prejudices were wrong? A magical possibility no one knew existed? A path others might follow?

YOUR ANSWER

Is their happy ending just personal, or does it change things for others?

IS THEIR HAPPY ENDING JUST PERSONAL, OR DOES IT CHANGE THINGS FOR OTHERS?

What work remains after their personal story ends?

If systems need changing, does their union start that work? Continue it? Complete it? Or is their victory just the beginning of larger change?

YOUR ANSWER

When Systems Collide

Sometimes worldbuilding elements seem to contradict. This can be productive tension or a plot hole, and knowing the difference is critical.

Productive Tension

When two systems create competing demands, characters face hard choices, and hard choices are the engine of great romance. (You mapped some of these collisions in the System Collision table earlier.) The key test: does the contradiction give your characters an impossible choice between two things they value? If yes, it's productive tension. Keep it. Lean into it.

Plot Holes

Systems break each other's logic:

- Magic resurrects the dead, but everyone treats death as permanent
- Teleportation exists, but the plot requires a three-week journey
- Mind reading is common, but political intrigue depends on secrets
- Healing magic is available, but characters stay injured for dramatic purposes

List potential contradictions in your systems:

LIST POTENTIAL CONTRADICTIONS IN YOUR SYSTEMS:

For each: is this productive tension or a plot hole?

Productive tension gives difficult choices and interesting conflict. Plot holes make readers stop trusting the world.

If it's a plot hole, you need to:

- Remove one contradictory element
- Add a limitation explaining why both can exist
- Make the contradiction itself part of the plot (why doesn't anyone notice this doesn't make sense?)

The Final Connection Check

You've already tested individual elements against other systems. Now zoom out and check the whole web.

These three questions determine whether your worldbuilding is doing its job.

Can I remove the romance and still have a complete fantasy plot?

If yes → Romantic Fantasy (romance enhances but isn't structurally essential)

If no → Fantasy Romance (romance is the structural core)

Both are valid! But knowing which helps you check if worldbuilding serves the right story.

YOUR ANSWER

Can I remove the fantasy elements and still have the same romance?

If yes → Worldbuilding might be decorative. Strengthen connections.

If no → Good. Worldbuilding is doing essential work.

YOUR ANSWER

Does every major system connect to the romance? Systems that don't connect may need reworking to serve the story, or might exist primarily for atmosphere rather than plot.

For each major system you've built (magic, politics, economy, culture, religion, geography, history), does it connect to your romance? For any that don't, either strengthen the connection or acknowledge it exists for atmosphere.

YOUR ANSWER

If you answered “no” to any major system, that system might need reworking to serve the story, or it might be worldbuilding that exists for atmosphere rather than plot.

Quick Reference: System Integration

	YOUR WORLD
The resource that creates conflict:	
The law that forbids them:	
The cultural value they violate:	

	YOUR WORLD
The historical event that shapes their obstacle:	
The system the antagonist represents:	
The trade-off they must face:	
What changes in the world when they succeed:	

Final Thought

Your world needs to feel so fully realised it feels alive. When you pull on one string, others react. That interconnection makes worldbuilding feel real, and makes your romance feel like it has real stakes.

The love story isn't separate from the world. It's shaped by the world: by the geography that isolates them, the economy that creates inequality between them, the politics that forbids them, the culture that judges them, the history that set these forces in motion, the magic that binds or divides them.

And conversely, the love story also shapes the world. Their choice to be together despite obstacles doesn't just matter to them. It challenges the systems that tried to keep them apart. It shows the possibility of different choices. It changes things.

Build systems that create obstacles. Then let love challenge those systems. Romantasy stories with the most satisfying endings show that choosing each other wasn't just personally meaningful. It had an impact on the world.